

Harvard University — Psychology A.B. (Cognitive Science MBB Track) + Harvard–NEC A.B./M.M.

Program Dossier · Prepared for Eidee Tan & Family · Fall 2027 Entry · Research date: August 15, 2026 · Admissions-lens addendum: August 19, 2026

This pathway pairs Harvard College’s **Psychology concentration, Cognitive Science track in Mind, Brain, and Behavior (MBB)** — a thesis-required, interdisciplinary cognitive-science program that reaches into computer science, linguistics, philosophy, and neuroscience — with the **Harvard–New England Conservatory dual degree**, a five-year program awarding a Harvard A.B. plus an NEC Master of Music. The single most important thing to know: the NEC overlay requires **separate, independent admission to both Harvard College and NEC in the same cycle**, including an NEC prescreening video due **December 1** and a **live audition in Boston in February**, and NEC enrolls only **five to six dual-degree students per year**. The Psychology/MBB side, by contrast, has no admission gate beyond getting into Harvard: students declare the concentration in sophomore fall, and the track’s one hard internal commitment is a **required senior honors thesis**.

1. The university at a glance

		Source
Location / type	Cambridge, Massachusetts; private research university; undergraduate college within the Faculty of Arts & Sciences	Harvard College admissions
Identity	<i>Veritas</i> — America’s oldest university; undergraduates study in a liberal-arts college of ~50 concentrations and 49 secondary fields	Advising Programs Office
Undergraduate enrollment	6,738 degree-seeking undergraduates (Fall 2025)	Common Data Set 2025–26
Overall admit rate	≈4.2% — 47,893 applied, 2,003 admitted (Fall 2025 entry, Class of 2029)	CDS 2025–26
Test policy	SAT or ACT required (rare alternatives such as AP/IB accepted in limited circumstances)	Application requirements; CDS 2025–26
SAT mid-50%	1450–1560 (enrolled first-years, Fall 2025, Class of 2029); ACT 33–35	CDS 2025–26
Application platform + fee	Common Application ; fee \$90 , waived for applicants with financial hardship	Application requirements; First-year applicants
Deadlines	Restrictive Early Action: Nov 1 (decision mid-December) · Regular Decision: Jan 1 (decision end of March)	First-year applicants
Financial aid headline	Family income under \$100K: everything billed is free (tuition, fees, food, housing, plus \$2,000 start-up and launch grants); \$100K–\$200K: tuition free , often more; need-based aid continues above \$200K	Harvard College financial aid
NEC overlay (if pursued)	Separate NEC application due Dec 1 with prescreening video ; live February audition ; NEC 2026–27 tuition \$64,208 (year 5 of dual degree)	NEC undergraduate applicants; NEC tuition + aid

2. The big picture — what kind of place this is

Harvard College is a liberal-arts college embedded in the world’s most heavily resourced research university. Undergraduates live in twelve residential Houses, choose from more than 50 concentrations and 3,700 courses, and declare their field in the **fall of sophomore year** — a full year of exploration is built into the design (Advising Programs Office). The curriculum is neither a rigid core nor fully open: every student completes four **General Education** courses, one in each of Aesthetics & Culture; Ethics

& Civics; Histories, Societies, Individuals; and Science & Technology in Society, alongside the College’s divisional distribution and related requirements (Gen Ed FAQs). Two of those Gen Ed categories — Ethics & Civics and Science & Technology in Society — map almost perfectly onto a cognition-to-technology-law direction.

For a student aiming at cognitive science as an intellectual home and technology law as a destination, Harvard’s distinctive asset is the **Mind, Brain, and Behavior (MBB) Initiative**: a university-wide interdisciplinary community that threads through seven concentrations (Psychology, Computer Science, Linguistics, Philosophy, Neuroscience, History and Science, and Human Biology, Behavior & Evolution), with shared foundational courses, interdisciplinary seminars, a junior symposium, and a required senior thesis, culminating in a **Certificate in Mind Brain Behavior** awarded alongside the A.B. (MBB tracks). Around it sits an unusually deep law-and-technology ecosystem — the Berkman Klein Center for Internet & Society at Harvard Law School, and the Embedded EthiCS collaboration between the philosophy and computer science faculties — described in Section 6.

Music at Harvard is large, serious, and mostly extracurricular. The Office for the Arts supports roughly **45 music groups**, including the Harvard-Radcliffe Orchestra and the Bach Society Orchestra, and the Music Department offers credit-bearing performance courses in which professionals coach chamber ensembles (Music Department, prospective students). For a musician who wants conservatory-level training on top of a Harvard degree, the College maintains what it calls “very competitive” dual programs with the **New England Conservatory** and Berklee (same page) — the NEC route is covered in full in Section 3.

3. The program — Psychology A.B., Cognitive Science (MBB) track + Harvard–NEC A.B./M.M.

3a. Psychology A.B., Cognitive Science track in Mind, Brain, and Behavior

Exact name and home unit: Psychology concentration (A.B.), Cognitive Science (MBB) track, Department of Psychology, Faculty of Arts & Sciences. Psychology offers three tracks — **General**, **Cognitive Neuroscience & Evolutionary Psychology (CNEP, the “Life Sciences” track)**, and **Cognitive Science (MBB)** (Psychology tracks).

Who it’s for: students who want cognition studied across disciplines rather than inside one department. The department describes the MBB track as allowing students to “combine coursework in Psychology with courses from related MBB curriculum including Linguistics, Philosophy, Human Evolutionary Biology, History and Science, Neuroscience, and Computer Science,” with less required biology than CNEP and a broader range of fields counting toward concentration requirements (Cognitive Science (MBB) overview).

Structure and course counts. Per the department’s requirements chart (August 2025 edition, latest published at research date), the base Psychology concentration is 12 courses; the thesis sequence brings the total to **14 courses**, and **the MBB track requires the thesis** — a student who decides not to write one must switch tracks (requirements chart; MBB overview). The pieces:

Component	Requirement
Introductory	PSY 1 (Introduction to Psychological Science)
Foundational	NEURO 80 (neurobiology; formerly MCB 81) plus one of PSY 11 / 14 / 15 / 16 / 18
Statistics & methods	PSY 1900 (statistics) and PSY 1901 (research methods, by end of fifth semester)
Sophomore tutorial	PSY 971
Advanced courses	Four: three “MBB Advanced Courses” drawn from Computer Science, History and Science, Human Evolutionary Biology, Linguistics, Neuroscience, and Philosophy; one Psychology departmental advanced course (MBB track courses)
MBB Junior Seminar	One 980-level interdisciplinary MBB seminar (MBB track courses)
Thesis sequence	One lab course for credit + yearlong senior thesis tutorial PSY 991A/991B ; thesis application filed and approved in the sixth semester
Non-credit MBB events	Junior-year Interdisciplinary Symposium and senior-year Interdisciplinary Research Workshop , required of all MBB students university-wide (MBB tracks)

What makes it coherent: the three MBB advanced courses are where Eidee would build the computation-and-mind spine — CS courses on AI and computation count toward the *psychology* concentration, which is rare. The thesis then forces synthesis: MBB theses must be “on a topic in mind brain behavior that has been approved by their concentration” (MBB tracks), and a project on, say, human trust in machine advice or cognitive assumptions embedded in AI regulation is legible both as cognitive science and as pre-law technology-policy work.

How MBB differs from regular Psychology: (1) the thesis is mandatory, not an honors option; (2) three advanced courses come from *outside* the Psychology department by design; (3) students join a university-wide cohort across seven concentrations, with its own seminars, symposium, and certificate. General-track students have none of these obligations — and none of the structure.

3b. The Harvard–NEC dual degree (A.B. + M.M., five years)

Exact name and units: Harvard/New England Conservatory Dual Degree Program — Harvard College A.B. (or S.B.) in any concentration + **Master of Music from NEC** (Harvard Music Department program page; NEC undergraduate programs). The undergraduate concentration can be Psychology/MBB — the dual degree is an overlay, not a replacement major.

Five-year structure (NEC undergraduate programs):

- **Years 1–3:** full-time Harvard student, living at Harvard, combining Harvard academic coursework with **studio instruction at NEC (one hour per week)**. The campuses are ~2.5 miles apart — about 30 minutes by bus, 20 by car or bike (Harvard Music Department).
- **Year 4:** complete the Harvard A.B. while beginning Master of Music requirements at NEC.
- **Year 5:** full-time at NEC, finishing the M.M.

Dual-degree students may join NEC performing ensembles “as their schedule permits” and remain free to take Harvard Music Department courses, pursue a music secondary, or even a joint concentration (Harvard Music Department).

Admission — two independent gates. Applicants apply **separately** to Harvard College and to NEC, must be admitted **independently by each**, and check the “Harvard-NEC Dual-Degree” box on both applications; NEC makes the final call on dual-degree acceptance (Harvard Music Department). Harvard requires no audition; **NEC requires a live on-campus audition in February from all dual-degree candidates**, judged to a *higher* standard than regular B.M. applicants (same page). NEC’s published cycle (current published dates; confirm when the 2026–27 cycle posts): application and **prescreening video due December 1**; recommendations January 15; prescreen-passing candidates invited to February live auditions; decisions late March (NEC undergraduate applicants; NEC audition requirements — violin repertoire is listed by department on that page’s selector). A safety valve exists: a first-year Harvard student who has never applied to NEC may apply to enter the program during the first year; students rejected by either school or by the program may not reapply (Harvard Music Department).

Scale: NEC describes the program as “one of the most competitive dual-degree programs in the world,” with “**only five to six students enrolling each year**” (NEC undergraduate programs).

Costs. During years 1–4 students pay **Harvard tuition and fees** (potentially reduced per-course for NEC credits transferred), plus an **NEC tuition covering the cost of studio instruction** (with an additional fee for NEC credits beyond studio instruction); in **year 5 students pay NEC’s Master of Music tuition** (Harvard Music Department). NEC’s 2026–27 graduate tuition is **\$64,208** plus ~\$2,000 in fees before housing; NEC reports 90% of its students receive scholarship support, based on need and artistic merit, via its institutional aid application and FAFSA (NEC tuition + aid). Each institution’s aid office handles only its own charges — Harvard’s generous aid does not extend to NEC bills.

4. How the pieces fit together

Harvard admission is to the College as a whole — no major is declared at application, and the concentration choice is made in **sophomore fall** with no competitive screen for Psychology (Advising Programs Office). The MBB track is entered through the Psychology concentration; its one mid-course commitment is the **sixth-semester thesis application**. One secondary field may be added: **Computer Science** (four Harvard CS courses, at least two advanced, with breadth tags; at most one course may double-count with the concentration — CS secondary requirements) is the natural complement, since it certifies the technical

depth that Psychology/MBB alone does not require. Psychology also offers its own secondary for students concentrating elsewhere (Psychology secondary field). Note that **MBB itself is not a secondary field** — it is a track-plus-certificate inside participating concentrations.

Scheduling reality: 14 concentration courses + 4 Gen Eds + distribution requirements fit comfortably in 32 courses over eight semesters, with room for CS50, statistics, and Gov or philosophy electives. Adding the NEC overlay costs weekly travel to Boston for studio, NEC ensemble time, and personal practice — the real constraint is hours, not course slots.

Gates beyond Harvard admission - Psychology concentration / MBB track declaration — *requirements-based, not competitive* (sophomore fall declaration; C- minimum in PSY 1900; thesis application approved in sixth semester). - **Senior thesis** — *requirements-based*; mandatory for MBB (leave the track if not pursued). - **NEC dual degree** — *competitive, twice over*: independent NEC admission (Dec 1 application + prescreen video, February live audition at a higher-than-B.M. standard) and final dual-degree selection by NEC; ~5–6 enrollees/year. - **OFA Music Lesson Subsidy** — *requirements-based with proficiency review*; only for financial-aid recipients; **not available to dual-degree students** (OFA subsidy page). - **Berkman Klein internships, lab RA positions** — *competitive applications; never guaranteed*.

5. An illustrative four-year path

Illustrative only — not official advising. The fifth year applies only if the NEC dual degree is pursued.

Year	Academics	Music
1	PSY 1, NEURO 80, PSY 1900; CS50; Expository Writing; Gen Eds (Ethics & Civics; Science & Technology in Society)	HRO or Bach Society audition; NEC studio (1 hr/wk) if in dual program — or first-year application to it
2	Declare Psychology (MBB) in fall ; PSY 971 sophomore tutorial; second foundational course; PSY 1901; first MBB advanced course (e.g., a CS or philosophy-of-mind course)	Ensemble + chamber coaching course in the Music Department; OFA lesson subsidy (if not dual-degree)
3	Two more MBB advanced courses; MBB Junior Seminar (980-level) ; lab course for credit; junior Interdisciplinary Symposium ; thesis application in spring ; CS secondary courses	NEC studio continues; NEC ensembles as schedule permits
4	PSY 991A/B senior thesis (e.g., human cognition and AI-mediated decisions); Psychology departmental advanced course; senior Interdisciplinary Research Workshop ; finish Gen Ed/distribution; graduate with A.B. + MBB certificate	Dual-degree students begin M.M. requirements at NEC
5 (NEC only)	—	Full-time at NEC; complete Master of Music

6. Beyond the classroom

The MBB community is the built-in research network: interdisciplinary seminars, the junior symposium, and the senior research workshop put Eidee in a cross-departmental cohort of thesis-writing students from Psychology, CS, Linguistics, Philosophy, and Neuroscience (MBB tracks). Thesis lab placement is arranged with individual faculty — abundant but applicant-driven.

Law, policy, and AI ethics. The **Berkman Klein Center for Internet & Society** at Harvard Law School runs a paid summer internship program open to undergraduates (2026 cycle: \$21/hour, application due March 22, with tracks in technical and non-technical AI research) — genuinely accessible to Harvard College students but competitive and re-announced each year (Berkman Klein Summer 2026 internships). **Embedded EthiCS**, a joint venture of the philosophy and CS faculties, weaves philosopher-taught ethics modules (privacy, discrimination in ML, accessibility) directly into standard CS courses, so ethics arrives with the technical material rather than as an elective (Embedded EthiCS). In Government, the **Tech Science program of study** (Gov 1430 “Tech Science to Save the World,” Gov 1433 “From Democracy to Technocracy and Back Again,” plus a practicum) is designed for Government concentrators — Eidee could not complete the program inside a Psychology

concentration, but the individual Gov courses are regular Harvard courses she can take as electives, subject to normal enrollment (Tech Science requirements).

Violin life. Outside NEC, Harvard offers ~45 OFA-supported ensembles — including the **Harvard-Radcliffe Orchestra** and Bach Society Orchestra — plus credit-bearing chamber-music courses coached by master performers in the Music Department (prospective-student music page). The department does **not** provide regular private lessons; instead, the **OFA Music Lesson Subsidy Program** supports lessons with outside teachers for full-time undergraduates *receiving financial aid*: typically **50–60% of lesson costs, averaging ~\$400/semester for up to six lessons**, renewed on demonstrated follow-through — explicitly not open to Harvard/NEC dual-degree students, and not for beginners (OFA Music Lesson Subsidy Program). Music concentrators receive separate departmental lesson funding from sophomore year.

7. Access, feasibility, and honest risks

The NEC gate is very narrow. Five to six enrollees a year, a February live-audition requirement judged above B.M. standard, and no reapplication after a rejection (NEC undergraduate programs; Harvard Music Department). The plan must be excellent *without* it: if NEC does not happen, the first-year application window is a second chance, and Harvard's own music life plus the lesson subsidy is the fallback — though the subsidy (~\$400/semester) funds far less instruction than a conservatory studio.

The MBB thesis is a commitment, not an option. A student who reaches junior year and does not want a thesis must leave the track (MBB overview). Relatedly, Psychology/MBB requires no programming or advanced math — the technical depth a future AI/IP lawyer needs must be self-imposed via the CS secondary or deliberate electives.

No undergraduate law or policy concentration exists, and the Government Tech Science *program* is closed to non-Gov concentrators; the law-and-technology layer is assembled from electives, Gen Ed, Berkman Klein-style opportunities, and the thesis topic. Research placements and internships are applications, not entitlements.

When a different Harvard pathway would be better: if institutions and governance come to outrank experimental cognition, the Government concentration with the Tech Science program of study becomes the stronger spine; if building systems outranks studying minds, Computer Science (which has its own MBB track — MBB tracks) inverts the recipe while keeping the MBB community and thesis.

8. Applying — admissions lens and logistics for Fall 2027

8a. Harvard's admissions lens: achievement as evidence of future contribution

Interpretive model, not a secret rubric. The screenshots supplied on August 19 contain useful intuitions, but they are anonymous social-media commentary, not Harvard policy. The model below keeps only the parts supported by Harvard's current public guidance or clearly labeled historical court records. Harvard says there is no formula for admission.

Harvard's current language is unusually future-facing: it seeks promising students who will contribute to the College during their undergraduate years and to society throughout their lives. At the same time, it explicitly considers present academic accomplishment, special talents, life-formed perspectives, respectful engagement with differing ideas, and the ability to use Harvard's opportunities. Its admissions FAQ separately names community involvement, leadership, extracurricular distinction, character, and personal qualities (First-year applicants; admissions criteria).

Historical court records make one part of that whole-person review more concrete. The First Circuit described Harvard's then-current personal rating as an assessment of applicants' positive effects on people around them and likely contribution to Harvard, informed by qualities such as leadership, maturity, integrity, response to setbacks, concern for others, helpfulness, courage, and kindness. The same opinion stresses that category ratings were preliminary rather than a mechanical formula; even among the exceptionally small group receiving the top academic rating in the years studied, 68.9% were admitted (First Circuit opinion, pp. 13-18). Historical interviewer guidance quoted in the litigation also named intellectual imagination, strength of character, and good judgment as dimensions of excellence beyond grades and scores (Card rebuttal report, pp. 10-12). These records describe an earlier process and should not be treated as proof that Harvard's 2026-27 internal forms are identical.

Viral claim	Evidence-backed principle	Disciplined application use
"They admit the 45-year-old, not the 17-year-old."	Harvard considers future contribution, but it infers promise from the applicant's present record.	Show a direction of travel: repeated choices, increasing responsibility, and a question or commitment that is still compounding. Do not announce a grand future title.
"The personal rating measures how well you handle people, not whether you are nice."	Relational effect matters, but kindness, concern for others, integrity, maturity, resilience, and helpfulness were themselves documented considerations.	Give concrete evidence of how another person, team, or community was better able to act because of the applicant. Do not manufacture charm or dominance.
"Harvard is looking for social skills."	Harvard values contribution to classmates and respectful engagement across disagreement. That is broader than extroversion or popularity.	Show listening, repair, persuasion, shared ownership, or quiet leadership. The relevant question is not who commands the room, but what changes in the room because the applicant is there.
"Harvard rejects the finished product."	Harvard values both demonstrated excellence and capacity to keep learning and using opportunity.	Do not hide accomplishment or perform artificial incompleteness. Pair excellence with curiosity, revision, and an unfinished question that follows naturally from real work.
"Harvard rewards judgment and punishes grind."	Good judgment can distinguish meaningful work, but effort, commitment, dedication, and sustained involvement also matter.	Hours establish commitment. The stronger evidence is what the applicant noticed, which tradeoff she understood, what she decided, how others were affected, and what changed in her next action.

The strategic heuristic is:

Credible future contribution = demonstrated excellence + judgment + relational effect + learning velocity.

This is an essay-planning model, not an admissions score.

The application should therefore reveal a repeatable operating pattern:

problem or opportunity -> judgment -> action -> effect on others -> reflection -> more capable next action

What this means for Eidee

- **Violin and the arts portfolio establish excellence.** The written application should add what a recording cannot: how she listens, makes interpretive decisions, responds when her first judgment is wrong, and affects an ensemble or younger musician.
- **Octave, SYSO, and orchestra leadership are strongest as relational evidence.** Prefer one specific instance of inviting participation, resolving a disagreement, transferring ownership, or enabling someone younger to act over a list of leadership duties.
- **TUNE and the sustainability-reporting internship can demonstrate judgment.** The valuable material is not the tool stack or number of hours. It is the assumption she tested, the evidence that contradicted it, the competing constraints she recognized, and the better question or decision that followed.
- **The cognition-to-technology-law direction can establish trajectory.** Make it credible through present questions and present action. Do not write as though Harvard is selecting a predetermined forty-five-year-old lawyer.
- **Warmth and humor should remain human rather than strategic.** The egg story, family rituals, and ordinary quirks can make the reader know Eidee, but they should never be engineered as an attempt to "win" a personal rating.

Do not infer from this model: that awards are liabilities; that Harvard prefers applicants with shorter resumes; that extroverts are favored; that effort is irrelevant; that an IMO medalist is routinely rejected for being too accomplished; or that the historical personal-rating form remains unchanged. The strongest defensible conclusion is narrower: **Harvard is not choosing between achievement, character, and potential. It asks whether the applicant's present record makes future contribution credible.**

8b. Logistics for Fall 2027

Item	Detail
Platform	Common Application (application requirements)
Fee	\$90 , waived for financial hardship (first-year applicants)
Restrictive Early Action	November 1, 2026 ; decision mid-December. REA bars simultaneous ED/EA/REA applications to other private institutions and binding early programs at publics; RD elsewhere and non-binding public/foreign early programs remain allowed (first-year applicants)
Regular Decision	January 1, 2027 ; decision end of March
Testing	SAT or ACT required (the CDS confirms scores are “required to be considered” for Fall 2027 applicants). REA: test by end of October (November sittings acceptable); RD: SAT through December, ACT through February. Self-reported scores accepted; official scores upon enrolling (first-year applicants; CDS 2025–26)
Arts supplement	Optional music recordings via Slideroom, small fee (waivable) (application requirements)
Interviews	Not addressed on the requirements page reviewed; Harvard has historically offered optional alumni interviews — confirm on the admissions site during the cycle
Financial aid forms	CSS Profile (code 3434), IDOC, and FAFSA (code E00468) — due Nov 1 for REA, Feb 1 for RD (prospective-student aid instructions); same process for international students (applying for aid)
NEC (dual degree)	NEC application + prescreening video: December 1, 2026 ; recommendations/transcripts January 15; live audition at NEC in February 2027 (required for dual-degree candidates); decisions late March; NEC aid application + FAFSA priority February 15. Check the dual-degree box on both applications (NEC undergraduate applicants; Harvard Music Department). Dates shown are the currently published cycle; re-verify when NEC posts the 2026–27 dates in September

9. Sources

Admissions lens & methodology: First-year applicants · Admissions criteria FAQ · Extracurricular activities FAQ · First Circuit opinion describing the historical reading process · Card rebuttal report quoting historical interviewer guidance · Anonymous social-media screenshots supplied August 19, 2026, treated as hypotheses only, not as evidence of Harvard policy.

Admissions & aid: First-year applicants · Application requirements · Common Data Set 2025–26 (OIRA) · Financial aid overview · Prospective-student aid forms · Applying for aid

Program: Psychology tracks · Cognitive Science (MBB) overview · MBB track course requirements · Requirements chart (Aug 2025) · Psychology secondary field · MBB Initiative tracks · CS secondary field · Gen Ed FAQs · Concentrations & secondaries (Advising) · Gov Tech Science requirements · Embedded EthiCS · Berkman Klein Summer 2026 internships

Music: Harvard–NEC dual degree (Harvard Music Dept.) · NEC undergraduate programs · NEC undergraduate applicants · NEC audition requirements · NEC tuition + aid · Music for prospective undergraduates · OFA Music Lesson Subsidy Program